

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Sustainability

Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Sustainability competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of sustainability as balancing the environmental, social, economic and administrative considerations that will impact a project.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

3. Understand sustainability as balancing the environmental, social, economic and administrative considerations that will impact a project.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- 3.a) Understand why sustainability responsibilities, principles and priorities are considered within a project and the impact they may have.
- 3.b) Knowledge of how sustainability measures are monitored and reported on.

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1–2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Sustainability:

- APM *Body of Knowledge 7th edition*, 1.3.3 (Sustainability)
- APM (2022) Thinking beyond a project to bring sustainable value to society: [Thinking beyond a project to bring sustainable value to society \(apm.org.uk\)](https://www.apm.org.uk/thinking-beyond-a-project-to-bring-sustainable-value-to-society)
- APM (2022) Make climate action part of your project: [Make climate action part of your project \(apm.org.uk\)](https://www.apm.org.uk/make-climate-action-part-of-your-project)
- APM Delivering sustainability in projects: <https://youtu.be/r9kka5Ge3io>

Overview

As the scarcity of global resources and environmental impact become more prominent concerns, it is important that organisations build sustainability into any project from the outset as part of the overarching project vision.

To ensure the sustainability of a project, you must balance these four elements:

- **Environmental impact**

This may include the impact of the project on climate change, biodiversity, as well as energy efficiency.

- **Social impact**

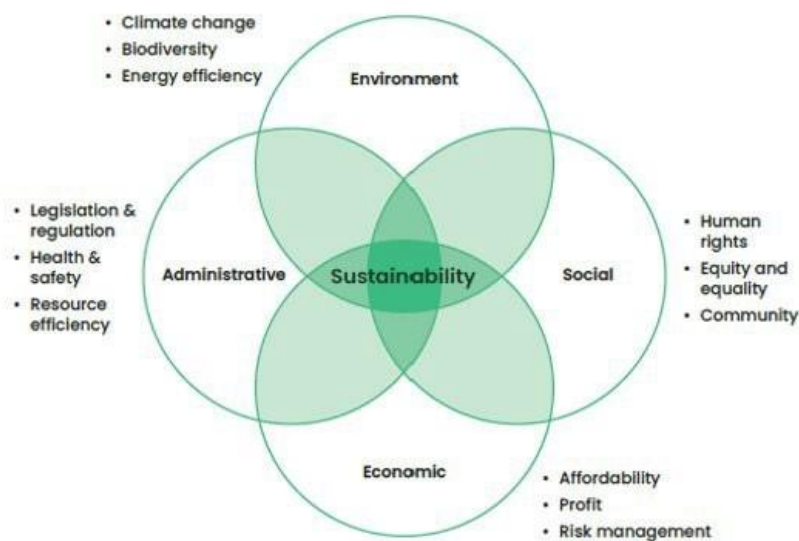
This may include consideration given to diversity, equality and inclusion, impact on communities and human rights factors.

- **Economic impact**

This may include recognising risk management factors, affordability and overall profitability.

- **Administrative concerns**

This may include consideration given to legislation and regulation, health and safety, as well as resource efficiency.



There are several sustainability frameworks standards and best practices that organisations can align to, including the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), B-Corporation Certification, or the Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) criteria.

Future business cases should be aligned to the organisation's sustainability agenda and be considered when examining product design, manufacturing processes, energy consumption, waste management and stakeholder relationships.

Stakeholder perception and engagement is incredibly important to ensuring any project's continued sustainability.

Consideration should be given to engaging internal and external communities (particularly ensuring individual responsibility), providing transparent and credible data and metrics, as well as the use of universally recognised data collection and analysis techniques such as the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI).

There are many ways that sustainability measures can be monitored and reported on, including:

- Proactive tools and techniques – ISO 14001, LEED, B Corp, Sustainability Accounting Standards Board (SASB).
- Measures and metrics for sustainability assessment – Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) data, Operational Carbon Usage data, and Embodied Carbon Measures.
- Positive or adverse impact on change initiative – project outputs, outcomes and benefits over lifecycles and during their creation, disposal and decommissioning.

Scenario One:

Sandeep, the Head of Development, has come to you with a dilemma. In their role, they are responsible for the creation of the apps that form the basis for the company's success.

However, more and more recently their developers have been complaining about the restrictive technology and software they are currently using and the impact that it is having on their productivity.

Both Sandeep and the CEO Ayo recognise the importance of expanding their developers' technical diversity into different sorts of technology including .NET, PHP and Java as the company strives to keep up with the demands of customers. This means bringing in tools like Visual Studio Code and PHPStorm to allow the developers to write code more quickly and effectively.

This kind of expansion will also require substantial increases in computer hardware capabilities including memory, output, processing (both Central Processing Units – CPUs and Graphics Processing Units – GPUs) and storage, or MOPS as Sandeep likes to call it.

As a result, Ayo has approved the purchasing of new systems, devices and software to ensure the continued viability of Snappy Appy. This is great news as far as Sandeep is concerned, but it has come with a caveat – Ayo has become increasingly interested in gaining B-Corp certified status for the organisation and as a result she wants every possible consideration given to ensuring that the transition to the new equipment and software is done as sustainably as possible.

Certified B-Corporations are recognised as leaders in the growing movement to make places of work inclusive, equitable, regenerative and sustainable. The ability to demonstrate high social and environmental performance is a must to gain the certification and this is why Ayo is so interested in making sure that this technology project goes smoothly.

Given the nature of this project, what are some of the environmental, administrative, social and economic sustainability concerns that you might need to consider?

Scenario Two:

In addition to becoming B-Corp certified, Ayo has also been looking at their annual awards given to top performing companies in various categories called the 'Best for the World' awards.

They are very interested in the Environment Award and as a result what is going to be done with the company's existing software and hardware and how it could be beneficial to the wider community, once it's replaced.

What suggestions could you make to ensure that the existing software and hardware is dealt with in the most sustainable manner?

Scenario Three:

Both Ayo and Sandeep want to ensure that the entire Snappy Appy 'family' are invested in this new shift towards sustainable practices, so they have asked that you draft a 'Success through Sustainability' handbook that outlines the expectations of each of the staff members.

The handbook should include how the organisation expects each person to conduct themselves in the most sustainable way possible, as well as give suggestions and tips for more sustainable ways of doing things in their workplace.

What kinds of expectations would you include in the 'Success through Sustainability' handbook?

What suggestions and/or tips could Snappy Appy give to staff members to make their workplaces more sustainable?

Scenario Four:

Due to the rapid growth of Snappy Appy, a Head of Marketing has yet to be appointed meaning that most marketing decisions are being taken care of by Alva, the Head of Sales.

They have been tasked with writing some copy for the Snappy Appy website that explains the company's commitment to sustainability, as well as the expectations that they have outlined to all staff.

Write 2-3 paragraphs for Snappy Appy's website that outline their sustainability principles, approach and measures.

You should ensure that you both inform and engage their customers, by referencing the four key sustainability elements and how the company is addressing each of them.

Scenario Five:

Sandeep has created a shortlist of potential suppliers for both the hardware and software required to ensure that their developers have everything they need.

As the Project Manager, you must ensure that the procurement strategy followed by Snappy Appy includes adhering to the sustainability principles that are now for all to see on the company website.

What information could you request from these potential suppliers that demonstrates their adherence to sustainable practices?

Scenario Six:

Ayo has read your first draft of the new 'Success through Sustainability', and they absolutely love it!

The only thing that they would like included is accountability for adherence to the Snappy Appy sustainability principles and they'd like you to include this in one of the sections.

What four key performance indicators (KPIs) would you include to ensure that all staff are doing everything possible to live the sustainability principles?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to discuss with other learners for the Sustainability section:

- The Sustainability Strategy is likely to have a significant impact on the organisation's success and the outcomes achieved:
- What impacts can you foresee based on the sustainability principles that that you've suggested for Snappy Appy?
- What could be some of the additional sustainability considerations that may be important to keep in mind when looking for potential suppliers to Snappy Appy?

What could be the potential impact of the 'Success through Sustainability' handbook to staff members? How could sustainable best practices be further encouraged or incentivised for staff members?

Exam practice questions

3.1 What is the definition of sustainability in a project context?
(1 mark)

- a. Involves both individual and organisational responsibility to ensure that project outputs are sustainable throughout their lifecycles.
- b. Involves organisational responsibility to ensure that project outputs are sustainable throughout their lifecycles.
- c. Involves both organisational and individual responsibility to ensure that project outputs are sustainable during the adoption and benefits realisation of the extended project lifecycle.
- d. Involves project responsibility to ensure that project outputs are sustainable throughout the transition phase of the project lifecycle.

3.2 Which two of the following statements are correct in relation to monitoring and reporting sustainability measures in a project?
(1 mark)

- 1. Sustainability monitoring and reporting will only be required in projects where there is a known environmental impact.
 - 2. Economic factors are not relevant to sustainability monitoring and reporting.
 - 3. Monitoring and reporting of sustainability will only be completed on transfer to Business as Usual.
 - 4. Sustainability monitoring and reporting can cover social and administrative concerns.
 - 5. Anyone on the project team can influence sustainability monitoring and reporting processes.
 - 6. Sustainability monitoring and reporting is the responsibility of the supply chain, not the project team.
- a. 1 & 2
 - b. 4 & 5
 - c. 2 & 4
 - d. 3 & 6

3.3 You are the Project Manager for a major infrastructure project to upgrade sea defences, protecting a small busy coastal town. The surrounding area has a rich range of wildlife habitats, supporting populations of several rare plants and animals, and the community is very active in protecting these areas.

What are two sustainability principles that you should consider as part of this project?
(2 marks)

What three potential impacts could there be if sustainability is not considered on this project?
(3 marks)

3.4 It is best practice to report on sustainability considerations_____ (a)_____.

Sustainability measurements can include environmental, social and governance data, as well as _____ (b)_____.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. At the start of the project
2. Throughout the project
3. At the end of the project
4. When requested

(b)

1. Budget spend profile
2. Quality indicators
3. Key Performance Indicators
4. Earned Value

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark Scheme
3.1	A
3.2	B
3.3	1 mark for each sustainability principle mentioned – 2 marks available in total: • Environment • Climate Change • Biodiversity • Energy Efficiency • Social • Human Rights • Equity & Equality • Community • Economic • Affordability • Profit • Risk Management • Administrative • Health & Safety • Resource Efficiency • Legislations & Regulation 1 mark for each potential impact mentioned – 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Breaching Health & Safety rules around building / Building Regulations , resulting in financial penalties / injury or death / legal cases. • Environment legislations and regulations not considered, which could result in financial penalties / environmental damage, and ultimately reputational damage for your organisation. • If community is not engaged, they could cause bad publicity / issues for the project, which could risk project success. • Social inequity if the needs of vulnerable/marginalised groups aren't considered • Economic costs resulting from potential clean up/remedial work/legal liabilities
3.4	(a) 2 (b) 3